when they retire they are assured of their pensions. India desperately needs more coaches like Pullela Gopichand, whose student, the world-class badminton champion Saina Nehwal, is a credit to his patience and meticulous grooming. And, if we are really serious about wanting to improve the situation, we need to be more careful about our selection of coaches: hire those who are capable and who share the same goals, give them four-year contracts on the assurance that their contracts will be renewed only after they have produced some tangible results. They must be made to understand that during this period their performance will be judged by how they and their students perform. The performers would then be rewarded, while the non-performers should be shown the door. Every country hires coaches on a contract basis, so why not India? But such a change will only be possible once the current group of coaches retires, and government and sports associations are ready to take on a new challenge.